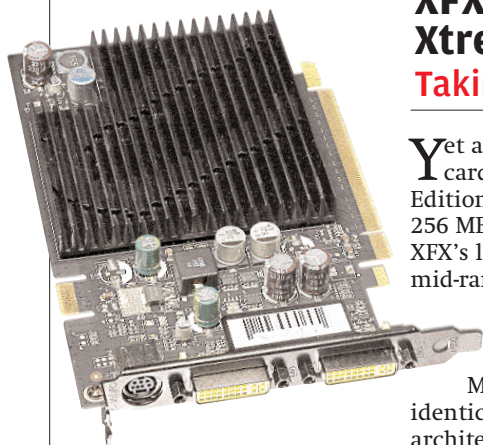




XFX GeForce 7600GS 256MB DDR2 DUAL DVI TV Xtreme Edition

Taking it to the Xtreme

Yet another 7600GS-based card! This Xtreme Edition card comes with 256 MB of VRAM, and is XFX's latest offering to the mid-range market. The core has been factory-tweaked—hence the “Xtreme” tag—to 500 MHz, making it identical to the faster but architecturally similar 7600GT.

This is one cool looking card: the PCB has a matte black finish, and both DVI connectors are a fluorescent green, matching XFX's brand colours (green and black). The black heat-sink is powder coated, with

nothing getting in the way of cooling. It managed a good job at cooling, and we never saw the temperature climb beyond the late 50s. The heat sink itself, however, gets much hotter than the two cards reviewed earlier.

Owing to the faster core, this card was expected to perform better than the other 7600GS cards, and it didn't disappoint: it led the other two cards by a minimum of 10 fps in our tests. The card also handled *Far Cry* beautifully with HDR off. At a resolution of 1600 x 1200 with 8x AF and 8x AA, the card managed a

commendable 55.75 fps. At normal settings, *F.E.A.R* saw 62 fps—very, very playable for a mid-range card.

The card comes with a decent bundle: *Starship Troopers* (a mediocre game), two DVI to D-Sub converters, and all the cables necessary to get you going.

Specifications

NVIDIA GeForce 7600GS chipset, 256 MB DDR2 RAM, core speed 500 MHz, SM 3.0 support, NVIDIA's Cine FX 4.0

Contact: Rashi Peripherals
Phone: 022-67090909

E-mail: navinderc@rpotechindia.com
Web site: www.rpotechindia.com
Price: Rs 7,500

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Package contents	★★★★☆
Value for money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

MSI K9N SLI Platinum

Enthusiastically built

Built around NVIDIA's spanking-new nForce 570 SLI chipset for AMD's latest AM2 processors, the K9N SLI sports the “Platinum” badge, meaning that MSI positions this product in the premium segment. As far as chipsets go, the nForce 570 SLI is a mainstream offering, behind the enthusiast-level nForce 590 SLI chipset. This chipset supports two x8 only slots in SLI mode, while the top-end 590 chipset supports two x16 slots. One major advantage for the 570 SLI chipset is, it's a single chip solution (the 590 SLI is a 2-chip solution).

Layout-wise, the board is decent, except that the IDE connector is cramped by the 24-pin power connector. A definite plus is the inclusion of three PCI slots; most SLI boards do away with at least one of these.

The board is sufficiently feature-rich. Six SATA connectors should keep

almost everyone happy, while the onboard HD-quality eight-channel sound is more than decent, even by today's relatively higher standards. One grouse we have is the quality of the chipset cooling used—a simple aluminum heat sink that gets much hotter than expected. Though we didn't face any stability issues, overclocking enthusiasts will rightfully expect at least a heat-pipe solution.

The BIOS is simple by enthusiast-board standards. Setting up and installation was easy enough. Our DDR2 800 MHz memory didn't boot into JEDEC-prescribed timings, but thankfully, the BIOS allowed us to easily remedy this. We ran the gamut of SiSoft Sandra's tests first and got some

interesting results. The Memory Bandwidth test gave decent results, just on the shy side of 8500 megabytes per second—a good score. We set up a 7900 GTX on this setup, and got a very respectable score of 7115.

We decided to set up a RAID array to check the onboard SATA RAID controller. With 112 MBps as a drive index in SiSoft Sandra 2007, the storage subsystem is juicy indeed!

Overall, the MSI K9N SLI Platinum is a good performer, and a very well-built board. Ideal for the gamer or enthusiast who won't skimp on the other “performance” components that will complement this motherboard.

Specifications

nForce 570 SLI chipset, Socket AM2, two x8 PCI express SLI-ready slots (single slot functions in x16 mode), six Serial ATA 300 MBps ports, HD 8-channel audio (Azalia) onboard.

Contact: MSI India
Phone: 011-41758808
E-mail: info@msi-india.com
Web site: www.msi.com.tw
Price: Rs 10,500 + VAT

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build quality	★★★★☆
Value for money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

